Westbrook City Council

~ Regular Meeting ~

Date: Monday, February 2, 2026
Time: Immediately following the 6:00 PM Committee of the Whole meeting
Location: Westbrook High School (Room 114), 125 Stroudwater St. (Hybrid via Zoom)
Video: https://vimeo.com/1161250730
Packet: https://www.westbrookmaine.gov/AgendaCenter/ViewFile/Agenda/_02022026-986

Timestamps below are clickable [0:00]-style links — they jump straight to that moment in the video.

This summary highlights the meeting's key discussions and decisions, with direct quotes and timestamps for verification — it is not a substitute for watching the full meeting. *Summarization necessarily condenses and selects; for complete context, nuance, and anything not covered here, watch the full video at the link above. (Produced by: WestbrookCurrents.com)*

Unofficial summary. *This is produced by Westbrook Currents, an independent site — not the City of Westbrook — and may contain mistakes. For the official record, see the City's approved minutes and the meeting video.*

Mayor's Message

ICE Enforcement Aftermath & Community Response [2:33]

Discussion Summary

Mayor David Morse addressed the aftermath of a recent surge in ICE (U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement) activity in the city, describing a large community mutual-aid response. Project Home estimates roughly **100 Westbrook households** may be at risk of eviction because household members were unable to work during the surge. The Mayor met with Governor Janet Mills and neighboring mayors to urge state-level action on downstream effects, and encouraged residents in need to contact the City's General Assistance department, noting a drop in requests he attributed to fear of coming forward.

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken.

Action Items

None.

Fire Department Staffing, Casella Update & Upcoming Items [7:00]

Discussion Summary

Fire Department: two paramedic/firefighter vacancies drew four fully qualified applicants; with two retirements anticipated later this year, Fire Chief Stephen Sloan requested and received approval to hire all four, temporarily raising authorized staffing from 46 to 48 until the retirements occur. The temporary cost is funded through TIF (tax increment financing) funds for the Spring Street and Waterstone districts, confirmed eligible after legal review.

Casella Waste: the Mayor met with Casella representatives about the service complaints raised at the prior meeting; Casella outlined process and training changes, with a follow-up meeting scheduled for spring to confirm progress.

Upcoming: Project Manager Robyn Saunders will give her annual city-projects update at the Feb. 23 meeting; Riverwalk North field work (test borings near Reserve, King, High, and Garfield streets) begins this month to assess soil/slope conditions for the project's design.

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken.

Action Items

None.

PFAS Update — GPCOG Memorandum of Agreement

[12:09] Project Manager Robyn Saunders outlined the funding path for PFAS soil testing at three sites (Fraser Field, Warren Field, and the Westbrook High School fields). The City's own EPA Brownfields assessment grant remains ineligible because the City authorized biosolid sludge application at these sites back in 1984 (though it's still unconfirmed whether that sludge was actually applied). Greater Portland Council of Governments (GPCOG) holds its own EPA Brownfields grant and has agreed to fund the testing instead.

The City will negotiate a Memorandum of Agreement with GPCOG memorializing the scope of work previously presented by Credere Associates — confirming the presence or absence of PFAS in soil above Maine DEP's remedial action guidelines, using both horizontal (incremental surface sampling) and vertical (deep soil boring) methods — plus site-restoration commitments, a regional communications plan for any detected PFAS levels, and DEP reimbursement of lab costs. A report is expected around May 2026, with a Council update likely by June. Saunders also shared the latest EPA guidance on PFAS health effects — reproductive effects, developmental delays in children, and altered cholesterol, hormone, and immune/vaccine response — noting effects vary by the specific compound found. The MOA itself will come to Council for authorization at the Feb. 23 meeting.

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken.

Personal Property Tax Outreach

City Field Appraiser Sara Larity — Business Outreach Initiative [17:26]

Discussion Summary

In her first presentation to the Council, City Field Appraiser Sara Larity outlined a new proactive outreach effort to improve business compliance with annual personal-property-tax declarations, citing a currently low response rate and underuse of the BETE/BETR tax-relief programs (Business Equipment Tax Exemption/Reimbursement). Planned actions include a postcard reminder, an improved mailer, a digital Excel reporting template, coordination with the City Clerk's office at business-license issuance, and in-person outreach during final inspections.

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken.

Action Items

None.

Council Messages

Snowplow Ride-Along & Community Resources [21:04]

Discussion Summary

Councilor Gary Rairdon described a four-and-a-half-hour ride-along with the City's snowplow crew during the prior week's storm, praising their coordination and skill ("my new name for them is Snow Placement Technicians").

President Munro echoed the Mayor's remarks on the ICE enforcement aftermath and listed community resources: Cater to Community (Mr. Bagel), Westbrook Families Feeding Families, the Locker Project, the Westbrook Food Pantry, Food For All Services (Portland), the Immigrant Legal Advocacy Project (ILAP), the Maine Immigrant Rights Coalition (MIRC), Project Relief, and Maine Needs, plus a school-sponsored basic-needs food drive collecting donations at the Transportation Department, Monday–Friday 9:30–2:00.

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken.

Action Items

None.

Public Comment (First)

Matthew Brunner (Stillwater Drive)

Reappointed this evening to the Recreation & Conservation Commission (see Resolve 2026-07 below), Brunner used public comment to advocate for filling the commission's two vacant alternate seats, specifically recommending Phil Spiller.

> *“There is no one with the know-how, the knowledge, and the passion for this in this city like there is, and it's Phil Spiller['s]... At this point it just seems to be like a personal vendetta because people don't like the way he posted about a park project on Facebook.”*

— Matthew Brunner (public comment) [26:47]

Chris Dudley (18 Haskell St.) — A Follow-Up to the Jan. 12 Suppressor Debate

Speaking without naming the councilor, Chris Dudley criticized a council member's response to a public commenter at the Jan. 12, 2026 Special Council meeting who had said she saw gun accessories as “toys for men.” For reference, that public commenter was Oriana Farnum and the councilor's remarks were Councilor Anna Turcotte's — both quoted in full in this site's January 12 summary.

> *“On January 12th, multiple members of the community spoke on their concerns with the police getting suppressors. The final speaker concluded her comments and then lightheartedly said, I'm not into guns, I see them as toys for men. Later, in response to the public's concerns, a councilor started by questioning the motives of the people speaking that day. That councilor went on to say that whoever said guns are toys for men clearly does not live in the real world... I appreciate all those men with guns that protect us and make this country the safest in the world. We're not the safest in the world. No entity that tracks safety data has this up in the top twenty-five. Let me be clear why I'm here: I'm disappointed that no one on the city council said anything... Civil discourse has a guiding principle. Don't make it personal. The public respected that. The council as a whole did not. Is that what we should expect from our elected officials? Please tell me you're better than this.”*

— Chris Dudley (public comment) [28:53]

No councilor responded to this comment on the record at this meeting.

Orders of the Day — Second & Final Reading

Orders 2026-06, 2026-07 — Credere Associates Riverwalk North Survey & Sigma Tactical Wellness Screenings [30:29]

Found on page 9 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Both first-read at the Jan. 12, 2026 Special Council meeting: Order 2026-06 (Credere Associates Task Order No. 7, Riverwalk North topographic survey update, $36,100) and Order 2026-07 (Sigma Tactical Wellness health/wellness screenings for public safety staff, up to $41,000). Moved together by Councilor Chau; no discussion.

Key Decisions

✓ Both approved together by unanimous roll call, 6–0 (Shaughnessy absent).

Action Items

None.

New Business — Liquor Licenses

Lenny's at Hawk's Plaza (1274 Bridgton Road) [31:54]

Found on page 41 of the packet. Public hearing held.

Discussion Summary

New owners Jill Piker, Susan Ericson, and Adam Steinman are taking over from longtime owner Bill Umbel, with a planned March 3 opening (hours extending to 11:30 PM, later than before). They said they intend to preserve the venue's existing atmosphere and live-music tradition, honoring the late Lenny Brough. Extensive warm public comment from councilors and residents with personal history at the location.

Key Decisions

✓ Liquor license approved by unanimous roll call, 6–0.

Action Items
None.

Ocha Thai (100 Larrabee Road, Suite 310) [39:31]

Found on page 54 of the packet. Public hearing held.

Discussion Summary
New owners Brian and Sysangvone Beardsley, nearly six months into opening preparations, are taking over a space vacated by a previous Thai restaurant (Phoever Maine) that relocated to Portland.

Key Decisions
✓ Liquor license approved by unanimous roll call, 6–0.

Action Items
None.

Resolves

Resolve 2026-06 — CDBG Applications, Program Year 2026 [42:36]

Found on page 68 of the packet.

Discussion Summary
Endorses four Cumberland County Community Development Block Grant (CDBG) applications: $200,000 for the City's own Riverwalk South Pedestrian Lighting Project (total project cost over $600,000, previously identified through the Capital Improvement Plan process, covering roughly Ash Street to the Black Bridge); $75,000 on behalf of the Intercultural Community Center (Patrick Drive) for a language-support program for low-income families; and two multi-jurisdictional applications where Westbrook is lead applicant, on behalf of Furniture Friends ($75,000, with the Towns of Freeport and Scarborough) and Project Home ($50,000, with the Towns of Scarborough and Windham).

Key Decisions
✓ Approved by unanimous roll call, 6–0.

Action Items
None.

Resolve 2026-07 — Recreation & Conservation Commission Reappointments [46:58]

Found on page 238 of the packet.

Discussion Summary
Confirms Mayor Morse's reappointment of Matthew Brunner and Warren Lain to the Recreation & Conservation Commission as regular members for three-year terms expiring Dec. 31, 2028.

Key Decisions
✓ Approved by unanimous roll call, 6–0.

Action Items
None.

Orders of the Day — One Reading Required

Order 2026-08 — Maine eCitation Printer Equipment Grant [48:46]

Found on page 241 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Accepts and authorizes expenditure of a $2,400 Maine eCitation Printer Equipment Grant for four cruiser printers.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved by unanimous roll call, 6–0.

Action Items

None.

Orders of the Day — Two Readings Required

Order 2026-09 — Emergency Replacement — Fire Department Gas Meters [50:16]

Found on page 246 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Confirms an emergency $20,607.85 purchase of replacement multi-gas meters and calibration equipment from Bergeron Protective Clothing (Epsom, NH) for the Fire Department. These three meters, among several already slated for future CIP (Capital Improvement Plan) replacement based on anticipated end-of-life, failed outright and needed immediate replacement under the City's mayoral emergency-purchasing authorization.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed first reading, unanimous roll call, 6–0.

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-10 — Emergency HVAC Repairs — Public Services Facility [52:38]

Found on page 250 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Authorizes contracts with ABM Mechanical of Westbrook, ME ($43,688) and Maine Controls of Portland, ME ($11,350) for emergency HVAC repair. Boiler 2, one of two roughly 10-year-old Bosch condensing natural-gas boilers with a poor maintenance history (from a now-discontinued Bosch product line), blew its cover off in late December and shut the system down, leaving the building running on the single remaining boiler at 56–64°F for about a month. Rather than repair only the failed unit (~$66,000) or just its heat exchanger (~$16,000, with risk boiler 1 could fail similarly), the City opted for full replacement of both boilers with Lochinvar units, along with a Tridium JACE control-system upgrade originally slated for the FY 2027 Capital Improvement Plan — moved up to avoid reprogramming the old, soon-to-be-unsupported controls twice.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed first reading, unanimous roll call, 6–0.

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-11 — Emergency HVAC Repairs — Walker Memorial Library [59:42]

Found on page 255 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Authorizes a contract with Patriot Mechanical of Gorham, ME ($43,636) for emergency HVAC repair. A 16-year-old heat-pump condenser's control board failed; since a replacement control board would have cost over half the price of a full new condenser on aging equipment, the City opted for full condenser replacement. The first unit shipped was incorrect by the warehouse; a correct replacement was pending at meeting time, with indoor temperatures in the 50s and low 60s (°F) in the meantime.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed first reading, unanimous roll call, 6–0.

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-12 — Landslide Vulnerability Project — Policy Development Services

[1:04:39]

Found on page 259 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Authorizes an agreement with Camoin Associates, Inc. (Richmond, VA, with local representatives in Scarborough, ME) for policy development services related to the Landslide Vulnerability Project, not to exceed $90,000 — the final phase of a multi-year project following the 2020 Presumpscot River landslide to understand and mitigate landslide-susceptibility hazards.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed first reading, unanimous roll call, 6–0.

Action Items

None.

Public Comment (Second), Referrals & Executive Session

Phil Spiller on the Recreation & Conservation Commission [1:06:26]

Discussion Summary

Phil Spiller thanked Mayor Morse for the Brunner/Lane reappointments and described the Commission's role in securing state Land and Water Conservation Fund and Recreational Trail Program grants, crediting Project Manager Robyn Saunders for executing both.

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken.

Action Items

None.

Referrals [1:09:32]

Discussion Summary

Friends of Warren Recreation Area introduction/updates referred to the Facilities & Streets Committee; cannabis dispensary zoning regulations referred to the Housing & Economic Development Committee. No committee reports.

Key Decisions

✓ **Both referrals approved by unanimous roll call, 6–0.**

Action Items

None.

Executive Session [1:10:44]

Discussion Summary

Council voted to enter executive session under 1 M.R.S. §405(6)(C) (real property acquisition/use/disposition or economic development where premature disclosure would harm the City's negotiating position) and §405(6)(E) (attorney consultation on legal rights, duties, or pending/contemplated litigation), with the Mayor, City Administrator, City Clerk, Director of Planning & Code, Director of Public Services, Interim and Deputy Directors of Economic & Community Development, Student Representatives, and legal counsel invited to attend; the transcript ends there.

Key Decisions

✓ **Motion to enter executive session approved by unanimous roll call, 6–0.**

Action Items

None.

How this was made

This summary was produced from the meeting video (linked above, hosted on the City's Vimeo showcase). The audio was transcribed with AI-assisted speech-to-text and speaker identification. This process cross-checked names and figures against the official packet and the city council roster, attributed speakers from context (introductions, roll-call order, direct address by the presiding officer) rather than the raw diarization labels alone, and drafted this summary and the quoted excerpts. Quotes are lightly cleaned of filler words/false starts but not reworded. Review tier: Not reviewed.

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